

of their seats until the very end. A battle between Martin and Bagnaia was always on the cards, especially considering how the previous season concluded: Bagnaia clinched his second title with a comfortable 39-point margin over Martin.

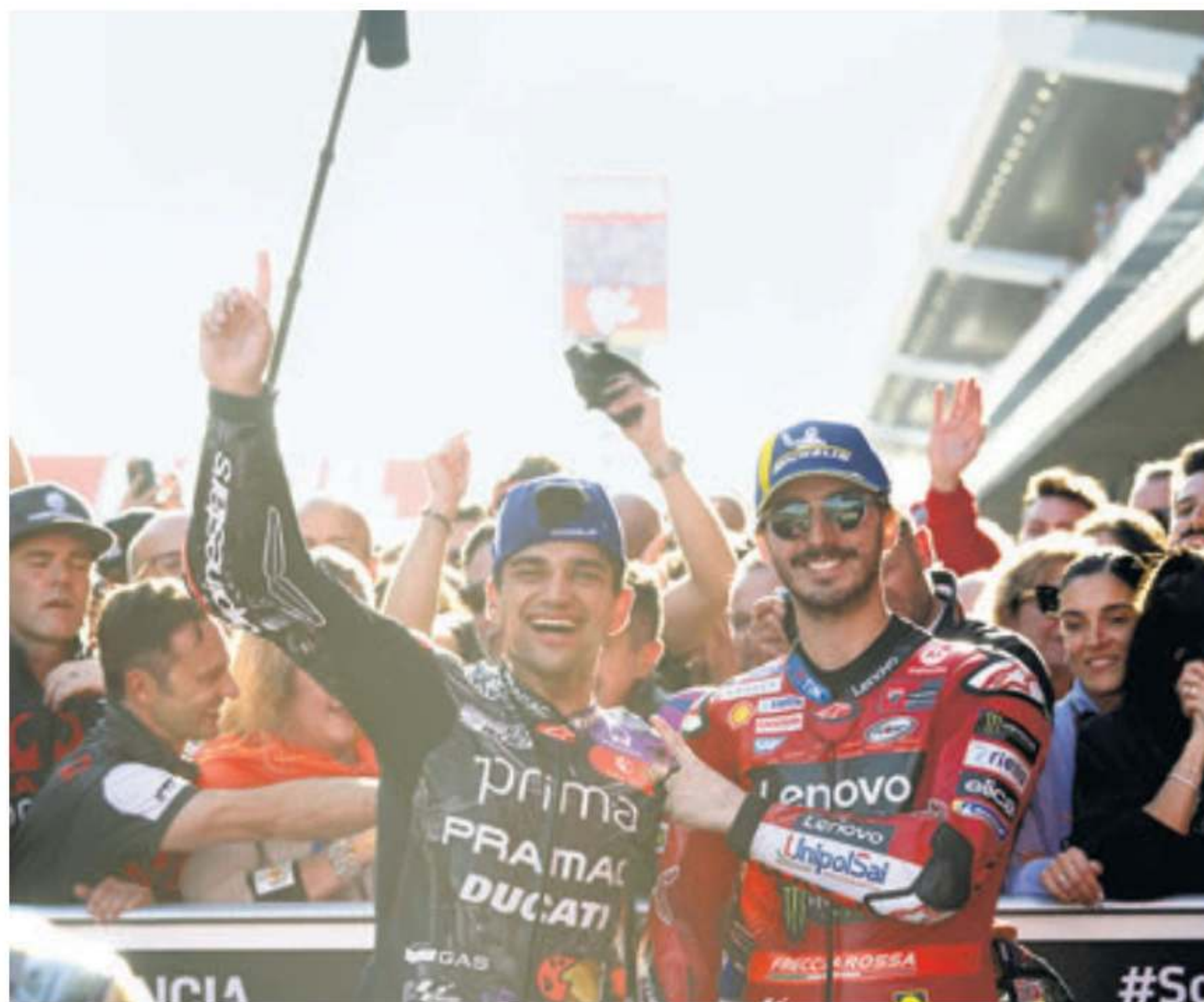
However, since the opening round in March, Martin was a man on a mission. He announced his championship challenge with a sprint victory in Qatar, followed by a P3 in the main race. Victory in Portugal in the next round put Martin at the top of the points table, a position he only relinquished to Bagnaia once. This time, Martin ensured he protected his lead by working on the one factor the lack of which he knew had cost him previously — consistency.

His strong suit has always been the shorter sprint races, and he maintained that trend, securing seven wins and 10 podium finishes in 20 races. However, it was his improved GP results that bolstered his campaign. Martin appeared on the Sunday podium 15 times — including three race wins — and maintained a critical nine-race point-scoring streak, consistently finishing in the top three. But Bagnaia never stopped knocking at his door, making use of every opportunity to edge past, or at least attempt to.

Bagnaia won a stunning 11 of 20 races, including the penultimate round in Malaysia, to keep himself in contention. The 27-year-old had a better start to the weekend at the Circuit de Barcelona-Catalunya, the stand-in venue for Valencia's Circuit Ricardo Tormo, which was dropped due to catastrophic floods in the region. Martin could only qualify fourth, handing the advantage to pole-sitter Bagnaia, who now had two attempts to cut the 24-point deficit.



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During the 12-lap affair, Enea Bastianini, Bagnaia's teammate, executed a perfectly timed overtake in the final lap to snatch second place from Martin, helping Bagnaia by the barest of margins and keeping his hopes alive. However, the bold move may not have been purely for Bagnaia's benefit, as Bastianini was also fighting Marquez for third in the championship.

Martin quickly climbed to second and maintained his pace behind the leader but had Bastianini breathing down his neck often. He certainly didn't anticipate a move of that nature in the final lap, but the Pramac rider chose not to engage and settled for third, aware that a tense showdown was yet to come.

When the lights went out on Sunday, Martin once again got a good start and was behind Bagnaia before being passed by Marquez.

Close encounter: The nail-biting contest between Martin (left) and Bagnaia (right) kept fans on the edge of their seats until the very end.

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Ahead of him were Ducati's new pairing for the 2025 season — a seat Martin had been vying for, which instead went to the 31-year-old Gresini rider. But at that moment, it mattered little. Martin knew he only needed a top-nine finish, and he achieved just that, though six places better.

Turning into the final corner, Martin was overwhelmed with disbelief and ecstasy, finally realising his dream at the culmination of a 10-year journey marred with injuries and setbacks.

A title that slipped through his fingers in 2023 was finally in his grasp, with Martin giving his team the perfect farewell gift. As he prepares to join Aprilia in 2025, the next conquest awaits — not hunting down his rival but defending his crown.